

Photographs by A. PRASADHAR RAO



PROBLEMS GALORE: Naidu on his Mee Kosam yatra; Nagi Reddy (standing) with his wife Sobha at an anti-Naidu meeting (below)

people are with us," he added. Ramakrishnudu, in fact, seemed confident that his party would emerge stronger out of the crisis as had been the case in 1984 and 1995. "Our party is like a stream that flows forever, irrespective of people joining or leaving it," he added. Naidu too claimed that the exit of "some" leaders would have no impact on the party.

The desertions could not have come at a worse time. Naidu's national image is at an all-time low after he decided to have a truck with the Congress on the nuclear deal and the Left still being non-committal over lending full support to the Third Front. And to add to his misery, there is the discomfort of Chiranjeevi being able to bring the communist parties to his side. It is because of this that the CPI(M) has been able to hold Naidu to ransom stating that an alliance with the TDP was possible only when it asserts categorically that it is in favour of an undivided Andhra Pradesh.

Chiranjeevi's proposed party has been drawing a number of film buffs in the same way as TDP once attracted

huge crowds because of the charisma of its founder N.T. Rama Rao, an actor-turned-politician. That is why, Naidu has now roped in his actor brothers-in-law Balakrishna and Harikrishna as troubleshooters to use their tinsel town glamour in containing defections. The party has been irked by Chiranjeevi's entry into the state's political space and has been saying that the actor's party will turn out to be a shelter for political migrants. "The proposed party appears to be shaky considering the poor response it has got from the people. That is why it has been relying on seniors from other parties by desperately hosting breakfasts, luncheons and dinners to seek their support," said Ramakrishnudu.

That the rebellion may spread further and faster has already been proved with several pro-Telangana leaders like legislator Kadiam Srihari, party vice-president G. Sukhender Reddy and former Union minister S. Venugopalachary, among several others, expected to put in their papers soon. But TDP's state of disarray has the Congress delighted. "There is a credibility crisis in the party because Naidu lacks the confidence of his own colleagues. TDP's cadres are losing confidence in their own leader," argues Congress chief whip N. Kiran Kumar Reddy.

A worried Naidu has now decided to step in to stem this migration by holding talks with his aides to review the grim situation. He also wants to draw up a strategy at a specially-convened meeting of the TDP state committee at Khammam on July 13 during the course of his marathon road show Mee Kosam yatra which began on April 21. He is also toying with the idea of shifting his party's earlier stand on a samayika or united Andhra Pradesh in the wake of these desertions. Naidu has been under pressure from partymen in Telangana to salvage a divided house. If he fails to amend the party's stand on Telangana and is unable to check the revolt, the drift is all set to continue. And as one wag countered, "The tyres of the bicycle, the party's election symbol, are already punctured." Allusions apart, the most severe test of Naidu's political career lies ahead and there is a possibility that he may not emerge successful from it. ■

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